

THE FORGOTTEN SEVEN



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CHAPTER ONE

THE BINDERY

The radio in the kitchen was already going when Owen came down the stairs.

“...and the new Light Grandmaster was back at Harbor Arena last night, folks, for her very first exhibition. Sixteen years old and five months on the job, and I don’t mind telling you, when Talia Reyes lit up that arena I had to take my hat off to shade my eyes. And afterward, when we asked her who that one was for, she looked right into the microphone and said, ‘*Cable Street.*’ How about that...”

“Turn it up!” Tess said.

Owen reached over and turned it off.

“Hey!”

“I’m eating.”

His sister glared at him. She was ten, sitting cross-legged on a kitchen chair with her trading cards spread over the table in neat rows, like she was running a bank. The seven Grandmasters had the middle of the table to themselves. The newest card sat right in the center, still shiny, with no bent corners at all. It showed a girl with her dark hair tied back in a high ponytail and her hand raised, light pouring off her fingers. Across the bottom, in gold letters: TALIA REYES, LIGHT GRANDMASTER.

And under that, in blue ink and slightly smudged, in handwriting Owen had been reading off notes passed in class since they were seven: *To Tess, my number one fan. Don’t trade me. —T.*

It had come in the post two months ago, in a stiff Ministry envelope with Tess’s name on the front. There had been nothing in it for Owen. There had never been anything for Owen.

“I’m never trading her,” Tess said, as though he had suggested it. “Not even for Rourke.”

“Nobody asked you to trade her.”

"People ask me *every day*."

Pop was at the stove with his sleeves rolled up and his work shirt already buttoned for the early shift at the Eastside power station. He snapped his fingers over the burner, and a flame the size of a match flicked to life and caught the gas. It was the same small, tidy flame he'd made every morning of Owen's life, the same one he fed into the boilers at the station eight hours a day, six days a week. His griamore sat on the windowsill with its cloth cover faded from red to a tired pink. It was thin. Most people's were.

"There he is," Pop said. "Sixteen. How's it feel?"

"Same as fifteen."

"Give it till lunch." Pop slid a plate across the table: one fried egg and a bun with a candle stuck in it. "Your mother left that before her shift. Says happy birthday, says don't be a smart mouth at the Bindery, says wear the good shirt."

"I'm wearing the good shirt."

Pop looked at the shirt. "That's the good shirt?"

"It's the one without the hole."

Tess was still watching him over her cards. "Do you think Talia will come? To the Bindery? For your day?"

"Why would she?"

It came out flat and hard, and the kitchen went quiet. Tess blinked at him. Pop glanced over from the stove and didn't say anything, which was worse.

Owen looked down at his egg.

"Light the candle," Tess said after a moment, quieter. "You have to make a wish. Everyone makes a wish on Bindery day. Talia made a wish."

Owen knew. He'd been sitting right there when she made it.

Five months ago, in this same kitchen, on Talia's sixteenth birthday, she'd sat in the chair where Owen was sitting now, and Pop had lit a candle in a bun for her too, because her own dad worked nights and somebody had to. She'd squeezed her eyes shut and wished so hard her nose wrinkled. Afterward Owen had asked what she'd wished for, and she'd grabbed his wrist under the table and whispered it, like it was a secret between the two

of them.

Something that gets us out of here.

Us, she'd said. Not me.

Then she'd gone up the hill to the Bindery and come back the Light Grandmaster, and it turned out the wish only had room for one.

Pop reached over and snapped his fingers above the bun. The candle caught.

Owen looked at it. Everybody knew the odds. Seven Grandmaster books in the whole world, and a Grandmaster book only came free when its holder died. The old Light Grandmaster had passed away last winter, at ninety-one, in his sleep. For three months after that, every sixteen-year-old in the country had gone to the Bindery holding their breath. Then one Tuesday in the spring, a girl from Cable Street had put her hand on a blank book, and that had been that.

And now it was happening all over again. Six weeks ago, the Thunder Grandmaster, a gruff old man named Barnaby Holt, had died in his armchair during a rainstorm, which the papers all agreed was very fitting. His book was sitting blank somewhere up the hill, waiting, and every sixteen-year-old in the country was holding their breath again.

But you didn't wish for Grandmaster. You wished for something good and steady, the kind of book people could build a life on: fire for the power station, water for the canals and the fire brigade, earth for the construction crews. Or one of the hundred other kinds of books people got every day. Strength for the docks. Healing for the hospital. Sound, if you wanted to work in radio. Metal, if you wanted to work anywhere at all, because the foundries were always hiring.

What Owen wanted was harder to say out loud, even inside his own head. He didn't need Grandmaster. He just wanted something that was *his*. Something nobody could look straight through.

He blew out the candle and didn't say what he'd wished for.

"Did you wish for Thunder?" Tess demanded. "You wished for Thunder. Everyone's wishing for Thunder. You can't get it, though. Talia already got Light, and Pop says lightning doesn't strike the same street twice."

"I said that one time," said Pop.

"You said it at *dinner*."

"Eat your breakfast, Tess."

"I already ate my breakfast. I'm doing inventory."

Owen picked up his plate and took it to the sink. On his way past, Pop put a heavy hand on his shoulder and left it there a second.

"Whatever you get," Pop said, "you come straight home after and show us. You hear? Straight home."

"I hear."

"Good lad."

* * *

Owen took the tram up the hill by himself.

He swung up onto the back rail without paying, like always, and stood with the wind in his face while Port Aldren rolled past: the fish markets and the cannery smokestacks, the big cranes at the harbor where the earth crews and the strength crews lifted cargo off freighters by hand, the laundry lines strung between tenements. Farther up, the city climbed the hill. The buildings got taller and cleaner there, with electric signs in the windows and motorcars shining at the curbs. At the very top, the Ministry's white towers stood with a government airship moored at the mast, its silver belly catching the morning sun.

Talia lived up there now. Somewhere in those towers she had rooms of her own, and a trainer, and a handler, and a schedule written out by the hour.

Owen didn't know which window was hers, and he told himself he didn't care.

At the corner of Market Street, the tram passed a warehouse with a poster on the side of it twenty feet tall. It was Talia, the same picture as on Tess's card: hand raised, light pouring off her fingers, her face calm and serious in a way Owen had never once seen it look in real life. Under her, in huge letters: THE LIGHT OF PORT ALDREN.

Somebody had drawn a mustache on her.

Owen looked away. He'd done it in the second month, with a stick of harbor chalk, climbing the fire escape in the dark. He'd felt good about it for about a minute. Then he'd felt stupid, and then he'd felt worse, and the rain hadn't washed it off the way he'd been counting on.

He leaned his head against the tram's cold brass pole and let himself remember the whole thing, all the way through, the way he'd been trying not to for five months. It was his birthday. He figured he was allowed.

* * *

He'd skipped school to go up to the Bindery with her that day.

She'd been so nervous she'd held on to his sleeve the whole time they waited in line, and when the clerk called her name she'd let go of it one finger at a time. She'd put her hand on the cover, and for a second nothing had happened. Then the gold Light mark on the ceiling, eighty feet up, had started to *glow*, and a clean white light had poured down out of it and filled the whole hall, every corner, so bright that for a moment there were no shadows anywhere.

Everybody in the building had gone silent.

And then Talia had turned around, with light still pouring off her like water, and she'd found him in the crowd, and she'd *screamed*. Not scared. Happy. The kind of scream you do on the last day of school. She'd run straight through the velvet ropes and thrown herself at him so hard they'd both nearly gone over, and she'd been laughing and crying at the same time, her face pressed into his shoulder, saying, "*Owen, Owen, Owen, did you see, did you SEE,*" and he'd been laughing too, spinning her around in the middle of the Bindery with three hundred people staring, and he had never in his whole life been so happy for another person.

"*Us,*" she'd said into his ear. "*I told you. I told you, didn't I? Us.*"

Then the men in grey suits had come through the doors. They'd been polite about it. They'd said *Miss Reyes* and *congratulations* and *if you'd come with us, please*, and they'd walked her out to a black motorcar at the bottom of the steps. She'd leaned out of the back window as it pulled away and yelled back at him over the traffic: "*Tonight! Come over tonight! Bring cake!*"

So he had.

He'd taken every coin he'd saved from coiling rope on the docks that spring, and he'd gone down to Sorrell's bakery and bought the best cake in the window, the kind with real sugar icing, and he'd stood there while Mrs. Sorrell piped *TALIA* across the top in gold, because gold was the Light Grandmaster's color and he'd wanted it to be perfect. He'd carried it all the way back to Cable Street in both arms like it was made of glass.

There had been a black motorcar parked outside her building. There had been two men in grey suits standing by the front steps, and a third one on the landing, and the door of the Reyes flat had been open, with light spilling out of it.

Talia had been standing in the doorway.

She'd changed out of her school clothes. She was wearing something white that he'd never seen before, stiff and new, and her hair was pinned up, and there was a tall thin man in a grey suit standing at her shoulder with a wristwatch he kept looking at. Owen had come up the stairs with the cake, grinning, and said, "Tal! Look. Look what I..."

And she had looked at him.

She'd looked right at him, for one second, with an expression he'd never seen on her face before and couldn't name.

Then she'd looked away, as if he were nobody. As if he were a stranger who'd come up the wrong stairs. She'd turned to the man in the grey suit and said something too quiet to hear, and the man had nodded, and she had gone back inside, and the door of the Reyes flat had closed.

Just like that.

Owen had stood on the landing holding the cake. One of the men in grey had looked at him, and then at the cake, and then back at the door, and hadn't said anything at all. After a while Owen had gone back down the stairs. He'd sat on the front step in the dark for a long time, with the cake on his knees and *TALIA* written across it in gold, waiting for the door to open again.

It hadn't.

In the morning, the black motorcar was gone, and so was she. She'd moved up the hill that night. She hadn't said goodbye. She never wrote. She never visited. Not one letter in five months, not one word, though the tram

went up the hill every twenty minutes and she knew exactly which window on Cable Street was his, because she'd climbed through it about a thousand times.

Two months later, a signed card had come in the post for Tess.

Nothing for Owen.

He'd given the cake to the Delgado kids on the first floor. He hadn't been able to eat it. He hadn't been able to eat anything from Sorrell's since.

* * *

The tram ground its way up the hill, and the Bindery came into view.

It was the biggest building Owen had ever been inside. The whole place was white marble, cold and echoing, with brass rails that split the floor into long lines and a ceiling painted with the seven Grandmaster marks in gold leaf: flame, water, air, earth, light, ice, and thunder, so high up you had to lean back to see them. The Light mark had been freshly regilded this spring, and it shone brighter than the others. Under the Thunder mark, somebody had hung a long black ribbon for mourning, and it stirred a little in the draft from the doors. Big brass electric lamps hung on long chains from the ceiling, and a clock hung on the wall behind every clerk's desk, and all of them ticked together, so the whole hall had a slow, steady pulse to it.

The line was full of sixteen-year-olds and their mothers. Owen's mother was at the cannery and his father was at the station, because you didn't miss a shift for a Bindery day unless you could afford to, and the Calders couldn't. It didn't matter. Plenty of kids came alone. He found the end of the line and stood in it.

A sign at the front said HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY in letters two feet tall. A man with a mop was leaning against the wall by the door, looking bored. Along the walls, every twenty feet or so, stood a Bindery warden in a dark grey uniform with a brass whistle on a chain and a heavy leather case on his belt. Owen had never paid them much attention before. Nobody did. They were there for the rare kid whose first touch went wrong, the fire that went up too high or the water that wouldn't stop.

It went slowly. At the front of each line was a desk, at each desk was a clerk in a green visor, and in front of each clerk was a stack of blank books: plain grey cloth, all the same. You gave your name. You put your hand on a book. And then something happened.

Owen had been to watch before, and none of it surprised him. It was the same every year. A girl two lines over put her hand down and her book went hot and smoked a little, and a red mark inked itself onto the cover, and her whole family cheered, because fire was the power station. A tall boy got water, and his book soaked through and dripped on the marble, and the man with the mop sighed and went over to it. A heavyset kid got strength and accidentally lifted the front of the desk an inch off the floor, and the clerk said *"Put it down, please,"* without even looking up. A small girl got healing, and a boy right after her got sound and said "Oh!" so loud it rattled the windows, and then clapped both hands over his mouth, horrified, while everybody laughed.

Nobody made a fuss over any of it. A book was a book. A mark was a mark. It was a good day, and a normal one.

"Next," called the clerk at the front of the line. The line shuffled forward. Owen shuffled with it.

Behind him, somebody gasped. Then somebody else did. Then the whole back half of the hall went quiet, and a murmur started at the doors and rolled forward like a wave: *it's her, it's her, that's the Light Grandmaster.*

Owen didn't turn around.

He didn't have to. He could hear her coming across the marble floor, fast, the way she'd always walked, like she was late for something. He could hear a man's heavier footsteps hurrying after her, and a man's voice saying, "Miss Reyes, *please*, the schedule." He could hear people shuffling back out of her way. And then he could feel it, the way you feel sun on the back of your neck, when she stopped right behind him.

"Owen," Talia said.

He looked straight ahead at the sign. HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY.

"Owen. Hey." Her voice was a little out of breath. "Happy birthday. I wasn't sure if you'd... I wanted to be here. For yours."

He didn't say anything. He didn't turn around.

For five months he'd had whole arguments with her in his head, on the roof, on the tram, in the dark before he fell asleep. He'd planned exactly what he'd say to her if she ever came back. He'd had speeches. He'd won every single one of those arguments.

And now she was right here, close enough that he could feel the strange warmth coming off her like a stove, and he found he didn't want any of the speeches. He only wanted one thing. He wanted her to know what it had felt like, standing on that landing with a cake in his arms, while a door closed.

So he looked straight ahead and said nothing at all.

The hall had gone very quiet around them. Everyone was staring. The Light Grandmaster, in her long white coat with the gold mark on the shoulder, standing in a Bindery line behind a skinny dock kid in a patched shirt, and the dock kid wouldn't even turn around.

"Owen," Talia said again, much quieter. "*Please*. I know. I know what I did. There's a reason, I swear there's a reason, I just can't..."

"Miss Reyes," said the man's voice behind her, low and urgent. Owen knew that voice. He'd heard it on a landing on Cable Street, five months ago. "Twenty minutes. The airfield. And people are *watching*."

"I *know*, Mr. Crane." A pause. Then, very quietly, to the back of Owen's head: "I'm going to stay until you're done. You don't have to talk to me. I'm just going to stay."

Owen stared at the sign until the letters stopped looking like words.

"*Next*," called the clerk.

It was Owen.

* * *

The clerk was a thin, tired man with a pencil behind his ear and a nameplate that said MR. PETTIBONE. He looked at Owen's certificate, looked at his ledger, wrote a number, and slid a blank book across the desk. Just grey cloth and blank pages, with a faint smell of dust and glue.

"Palm flat on the cover," Mr. Pettibone said. "Don't pull away, whatever it feels like."

Nobody was watching.

Owen realized it all at once. The whole hall was still staring at Talia: whispering, pointing, a girl two lines over trying to work up the nerve to ask for her autograph. Even Mr. Pettibone kept glancing past Owen's shoulder at the white coat. Owen was standing at the desk on his own Bindery day, the one day in your whole life when everybody is supposed to be watching you, and he was invisible. He was standing in her shadow, which was a funny thing to be able to do with somebody made of light.

Something hot and heavy went through his chest. He was ashamed of it, and it didn't go away. If anything, it got heavier.

He wiped his hand on his trousers. His heart was going hard.

He put his hand on the book.

* * *

The first thing he felt was nothing at all.

The book was cool and dry under his palm, just cloth, and for one long second nothing happened, and Owen had time to think, *Of course. Of course it's nothing. Of course it's me.*

Then the weight came.

It didn't come *to* him. It came *out* of him. It poured out of the book and up his arm and through his chest, and out, out in every direction at once, like a wave rolling out from a stone dropped in still water, except the wave was *heavy*, heavier than anything, heavy the way the bottom of the harbor is heavy, heavy the way the whole world is heavy when you're lying awake at three in the morning.

Mr. Pettibone went down first. He didn't fall. He was *pressed*, face-first onto his own ledger, as if a giant hand had come down on the back of his head. His visor cracked. His pencil shot off the desk and hit the marble so hard it snapped in half.

Then the whole line behind Owen went down.

It happened all at once, three hundred people, like a field of wheat under a sudden wind. Knees buckled. Mothers folded over their children. The heavyset kid who'd lifted the desk hit the floor on his hands and knees and then his elbows gave out and he went flat. The tall boy's wet book tore out

of his hands and slammed into the floor with a *crack*. People screamed, and then they couldn't scream, because they couldn't lift their chests to breathe enough to do it. All they could do was lie there, pinned, gasping, with their cheeks pressed against the cold white marble.

The brass rails bent. Owen watched them do it: long, polished brass rails sagging slowly toward the floor in the middle, groaning, like licorice left out in the sun. The chains of the great electric lamps snapped taut, and the lamps dropped two feet all at once and hung there, swinging and straining, the bulbs flaring and popping one after another in bursts of white glass. Along the far wall, the clocks tore loose from their hooks. They didn't fall so much as get *yanked* to the floor, all of them, one after another down the whole length of the hall, *smash smash smash smash*, until there was no ticking left at all.

The marble under the desk cracked. A thin black line ran out from Owen's feet, and then another, and then a whole ring of them, spreading slowly out through the white stone like frost across a window.

Dust sifted down from the ceiling in long grey curtains. High above, eighty feet up, the seven gold Grandmaster marks trembled on the plaster.

And Owen stood in the middle of it all, and he felt *light*.

That was the worst part. That was the part he would remember afterward, in the dark, for a long time. Everyone in the building was being crushed into the floor, and he felt lighter than he had in five months. Lighter than air. As if the weight he'd been carrying around since that night on the landing had finally, *finally* gone somewhere, and he never had to hold it again.

Then he looked down.

Nobody was standing. Nobody in the whole Bindery, not the clerks, not the wardens along the walls, not the man with the mop. Everyone was down, pressed flat, three hundred people lying on the marble with their faces turned toward him, and every single one of them was staring at him.

Everyone was watching him now.

The thought came, and it was so ugly that it frightened him more than anything else in the room.

He tried to take his hand off the book. It wouldn't come. It was the only thing in the building that wasn't heavy, and it was stuck to the cover like it had grown there.

"Owen."

He turned his head.

Talia was the only one moving. She was down like everyone else, but she was fighting it. She had one hand flat on the marble and the other pressed to her chest, and light was coming off her in waves, bright white-gold light, flaring and flickering like a lamp in a gale, pushing back against the weight. Her long white coat was spread out on the floor around her. Her jaw was clenched so hard he could see the muscle standing out. Slowly, shaking, inch by inch, she was pushing herself up onto one knee.

The Light Grandmaster, on her knees in the Bindery. On her knees in front of him.

"Owen," she said again, through her teeth. Her golden eyes were fixed on his face. She didn't look angry. She didn't look scared of him. She looked scared *for* him. *"Owen. Look at me. Let go. You have to let go."*

"I can't..."

"Yes, you can. It's yours. It listens to you. Just let go."

He looked at her. At her face, and her shaking arm, and the light pouring off her like it had poured off her five months ago in this same hall, when she'd run through the ropes and thrown her arms around him and said *us*.

Something in his chest let go before his hand did.

The weight *stopped*.

It didn't fade. It just stopped, all at once, the way a sound stops when you close a door. The lamps jerked back up on their chains and swung wildly, creaking. The dust hung in the air. The brass rails stayed bent. Three hundred people took one huge, ragged breath at the same time, and then the hall filled up with coughing and crying and a child somewhere wailing at the top of his lungs.

Owen's hand came off the book.

He looked down at it. A mark had inked itself onto the grey cloth while he wasn't looking, dark as a bruise, and it wasn't a flame or a wave or any of

the others from the ceiling. The book was thicker than it had been, and heavy, so heavy he could feel it pulling at the desk. Only the first page had filled. He could see a single word written at the top of it in dark ink, through the gap in the cover.

Gravity.

* * *

Nobody moved for a moment. Then everybody moved at once, scrambling back, away from the desk, away from him, dragging their children with them, bumping into each other in their hurry. A ring of empty cracked marble opened up around him. Nobody would come inside it.

Mr. Pettibone was sitting on the floor behind the desk with his broken visor in his hands, staring at Owen like he was a lit stick of dynamite.

And then, from somewhere across the hall, someone blew a whistle.

It was a long, sharp blast, and then another answered it from the far wall, and another from the doors, and suddenly the wardens were coming. They were dusty and bruised, some of them limping, but they were coming across the cracked marble from every side at once in their dark grey uniforms, and they'd opened the heavy leather cases on their belts. Owen saw what was in them. Cuffs. Thick, dull iron cuffs, with strange marks cut into them in rings, marks that weren't in any registry he'd ever seen.

"I didn't..." Owen took a step back and hit the desk. "I didn't *mean*... I didn't do anything, it just..."

The first warden reached him. Then two more. Nobody said anything to him. Nobody said his name. They took his arms, not roughly but not gently either, and turned him around and pushed him face-first against the desk, the same desk where Mr. Pettibone had been crushed flat a minute ago. Someone yanked his hands behind his back.

The iron closed around his wrists.

It was *cold*. Not normal cold, like metal. A deep, strange cold that went straight up his arms and into his chest and found the place where the weight had come from and pressed down on it, hard, until it went quiet. He felt his book go dead on the desk in front of him, like a light going out.

A warden picked up the book with a pair of heavy gloves, the way you'd pick up something that might bite, and dropped it into an iron box and shut the lid.

"Hey!" Owen twisted around. "That's *mine!* That's..."

"Walk," said the warden holding his arm.

"Where? Where are we..."

"Walk."

They walked him. Across the cracked marble, through the ring of people pressed back against the walls, past the bent brass rails and the smashed clocks and the swinging broken lamps. Everyone stared. Everyone. A mother pulled her daughter behind her skirt as he went by. A boy he'd been standing in line with an hour ago, the one who'd gotten sound, looked at him with his mouth open and didn't make a sound at all.

At the side of the hall, near the desks, an old woman with white hair and reading glasses on a chain was pulling herself up by a clerk's chair. She wasn't looking at Owen. She was looking at the iron box in the warden's arms, and her face had gone completely white.

"Stop!"

Talia.

She was on her feet. Owen didn't know how. Her white coat was grey with dust and her hair had come half out of its ribbon, and she was still shaking, but she was on her feet and she was running across the hall toward him, and the light was coming off her again, so bright that the wardens had to squint.

"Stop! Let him go! He didn't do anything, he didn't *mean* it, it was his first touch, it happens, it happens *twice a week*, you can't just..."

Mr. Crane caught her by the arm. Owen had never seen the man move fast before. He caught her and held on, even as her light flared hot enough to make him flinch.

"Miss Reyes. *Miss Reyes*. This is not your concern."

"*Not my...*" She wrenched against his grip. "*He's my...* Let go of me!"

"You cannot be seen with this," Mr. Crane said, low and very fast. "Do you understand me? Not now. Not with *this*. Not after everything we've..."

"*I don't care!*"

The wardens kept walking. The bronze doors were open ahead, full of bright morning sunlight, and at the bottom of the steps Owen could see a long black motorcar with its back door already standing open, waiting. He stumbled on the top step, and a warden's hand hauled him upright again.

He looked back.

He couldn't help it. He looked back over his shoulder through the doors, into the wrecked white hall, and she was right there. She was still fighting against Mr. Crane's grip, still reaching for him, her hand stretched out toward him across the cracked marble with light spilling off her fingers. And her face was the face he'd seen five months ago, on a landing on Cable Street, for one second before a door closed. He still couldn't name it.

But he was starting to think it might not have been what he'd thought.

"OWEN!" Talia screamed. Her voice cracked in half. "*Where are you taking him? WHERE ARE YOU TAKING HIM?*"

Nobody answered her.

The motorcar door slammed shut.